Food Remedy API

Competitive App Research: Open Food Facts [RE020]

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Introduction

The Open Food Facts mobile application is a companion tool to the open-source Open Food Facts database and API, enabling users to scan, search, and explore over three million food products worldwide. The app delivers barcode scanning, nutritional and ingredient breakdowns, health and environmental ratings, and personal profile functionality. Mobile applications that empower users to make informed dietary decisions have grown in popularity as consumers demand transparency regarding nutrition, ingredients, and environmental impact. The Open Food Facts mobile app extends the organisation's open-source database into an accessible consumer tool, providing a barcode scanner and product lookup service. Its community-driven nature makes it a valuable public resource, but its design and functionality also raise considerations for developers building alternative or competing solutions.

This report analyses the app's design, user interface, core features, and user experience, evaluating its strengths and limitations. It also identifies considerations and recommendations for incorporating lessons into the Food Remedy API application, particularly around privacy, allergen awareness, and customisation.

Overview of the Open Food Facts Mobile App

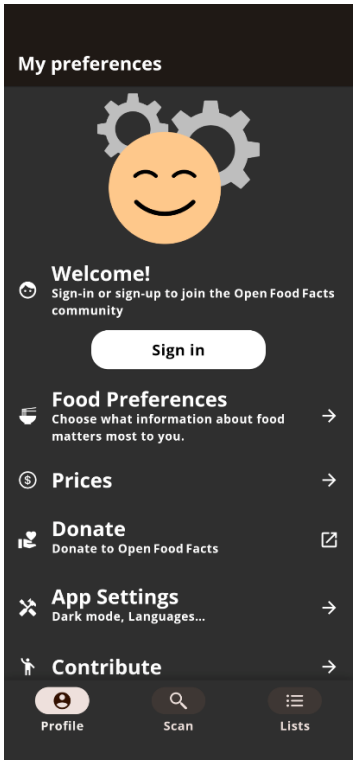
The app is available on iOS and Android, offering real-time access to the global database. It primarily serves three functions:

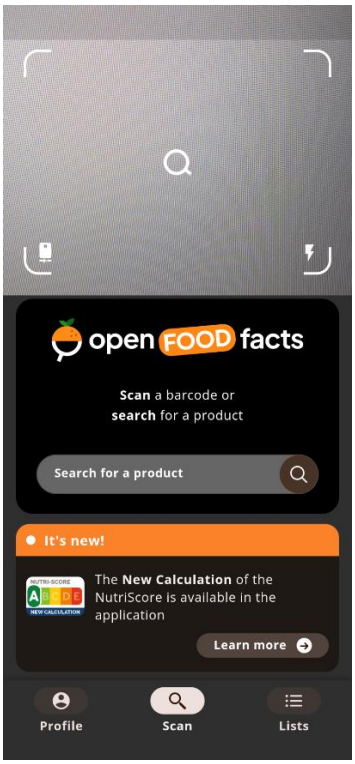
- Barcode Scanning and Search – Providing instant retrieval of product information.
- History and List Management – Allowing users to revisit scanned items.
- Profile and Settings – Supporting account login and user preferences.

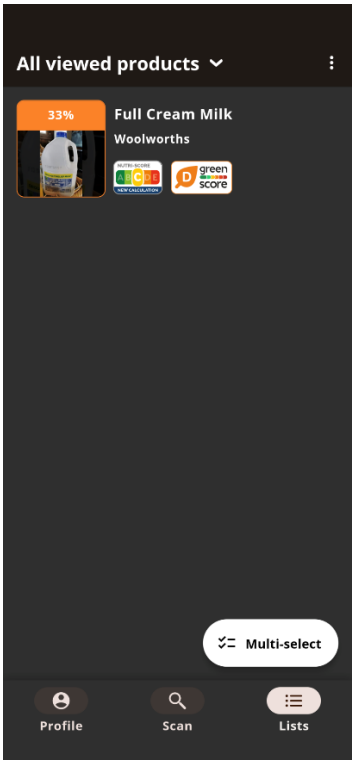
The app is minimalist, prioritising quick access to product details over complex navigation.

Screen and Feature Analysis

The following images outline the major screens for the Open Food Facts App







The app's landing page (Scan screen) combines

- A continuously active camera for barcode scanning.
- A search bar for manual product lookups.

While this ensures immediate scanning readiness, it introduces potential privacy and security concerns as the camera remains active without explicit activation. For the Food Remedy API application, it is recommended to:

- Move the camera to a dedicated screen, triggered by a button.

The List screen presents a chronological history of scanned items, allowing users to:

- Review past scans.
- Tap entries for full product details.

The Profile screen enables:

- User login and profile management.
- Preference configuration.
- Access to settings like data usage or notifications.

This supports personalisation but is relatively basic compared to more health-focused apps. The Food Remedy API can differentiate itself by:

- Enabling detailed allergen and intolerance profiles.

Product Results Page (Figure 3 below):

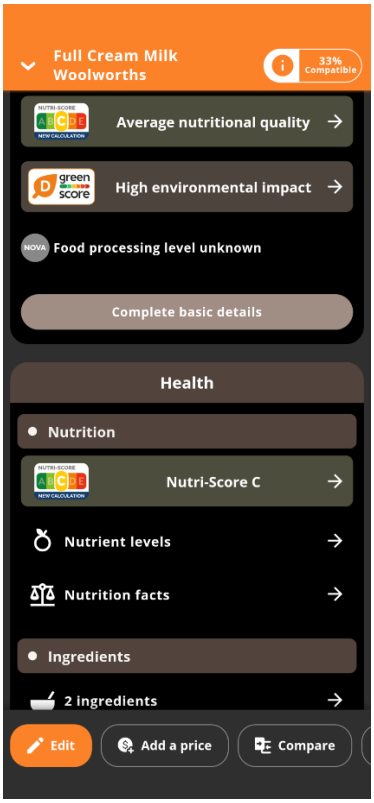
The product view is the core user experience, displaying:

- Product image, brand, and name.
- Nutritional breakdown (macronutrients, energy, sugar, fats).
- Nutri-Score rating (A–E).
- Environmental and packaging data (where available).
- Ingredient list, including allergen traces and additives.

While comprehensive, information presentation is often dense and text-heavy, which can overwhelm users. The Food Remedy API could improve this by:

- Highlighting critical allergen or intolerance alerts first.
- Using visual markers or colour-coded flags for quick assessments.
- Integrating custom recommendations based on user profiles.

Figure 3. Product Screen in Open Food Facts App



Conclusion

The Open Food Facts mobile application provides a straightforward and functional interface for accessing the open-source database of global food products. Its simplicity make it an effective consumer tool, but the app's design leaves room for enhancement in personalisation, privacy management, and health-focused features. For the Food Remedy API application, these observations highlight opportunities to refine user experience by prioritising allergen and intolerance alerts, and building more detailed and interactive user profiles.

Beyond its user interface, the greatest value lies in the Open Food Facts database itself. As a freely licensed, community-driven dataset, it can be integrated into Food Remedy API by migrating it into an SQL-based system for direct access and querying. Leveraging this rich data source allows Food Remedy API to accelerate development, avoid duplicating data collection, and focus on delivering added value, such as customised dietary recommendations, improved allergen visibility, and more user-centric tools that go beyond the functionality offered by the Open Food Facts app.